CHAPTER 2

LEAD TODAY, FOLLOW TOMORROW?

HOW TO MANAGE THE EBB AND FLOW OF LEADER AND FOLLOWER IDENTITIES

Summary

This chapter helps to navigate the day-to-day complexity of leading and following. It explains why seeing oneself as a leader and a follower is not something fixed but consistently changing, and how these 'identity ebb and flows' contribute to leader development. The chapter discusses how events within and outside of work can activate one identity over the other. It introduces a web application – the Leader-Follower Identity Tracker (LFIT) – which supports individuals and teams in assessing and reflecting on the complexity of leading and following from day to day.

Chapter Outline

Chapter Overview

What Are Leader and Follower Identities?

Why Do We Care About the Changing Nature of Leader and Follower Identities?

- New to Your Job? You May Feel "Betwixt and Between" Being a Leader and a Follower
- Are You a Middle Manager? Try Switching Between Leading and Following!
- Shared Leadership: When Team Members Are Both Leaders and Followers

Why Leader and Follower Identities Change

- Identities are Sensitive to Context
- Identities Are Interlinked With Memory
- Identities Operate at Different Levels

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Activating Your Leader and Follower Identities

Strong Events at Work

Strong Events Outside of Work

Strong Daily Events

Using Events for Self-Reflection

Develop Your Leader and Follower Identities From Day to Day: The Leader-Follower Identity Tracker (LFIT)

How to Use the Leader-Follower Identity Tracker

Step-by-Step Guide for the LFIT

Conclusion

Learning Outcomes

By the end of the chapter, readers should:

1. Be able to define what leader and follower identities are and why they matter
2. Be able to explain why leader and follower identities are constantly changing
3. Be able to discuss how both leader and follower identities contribute to leader development (Food for thought exercises #1 to #3)
4. Be able to evaluate situations, events, or contexts in which they saw themselves more like a leader, a follower, none or both (Leader-Follower Identity Tracker)

Case Questions

The chapter discusses three examples to illustrate the relevance of both leader and follower identities for leader development: Entering a leadership role and leader-follower identity liminality (example 1), middle managing and leader-follower switching (example 2) and

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sharing leadership (example 3). Instructors can use the *food for thought exercises #1* to *#3* to ask students to reflect on these three examples.

Personal Development Activities

Instruct students to use the Leader-Follower Identity Tracker (LFIT) to assess and reflect on the day-to-day complexity of leading and following, and to facilitate discussions in class. The LFIT prompts students to engage in short daily reflections (3 min) about their identity and event experiences on the respective day. These reflections should be completed at the end of each day and ideally over a period of at least two consecutive weeks.

Students can be instructed to complete the LFIT activity before class and bring their reflections on the results, or to complete the LFIT activity at any time during a course. If students are working on group projects, the activity could run in parallel to the project period, or be completed at different stages (e.g., beginning, middle, end) of the project.

Below a few exemplary reflection questions on the LFIT. These questions can be tailored to a specific group project by adding “during the period of this group project”, or a specific time point, for example “at the beginning of the group project”.

- What was my general leader and follower identity strength, that is, the identity state I felt most comfortable with?
- Generally, how much leader-follower identity liminality did I experience?
- How much did my leader and follower identities change from day to day?
- How often did I switch between my leader and follower identities from day to day?
- What happened on days on which I felt more like a leader (follower) than usual?

Links to Other Chapters

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- Chapter 3 (Jokisaari & Adriasola) helps to navigate transitions into new leader roles. Leadership transitions are strong events that can make you think in new ways about yourself. They may make you feel in a limbo between being a leader and a follower (i.e., leader-follower liminality). The chapter explores how setting and pursuing personal and shared goals helps you making sense ad navigating through transitions.
- Chapter 5 (Fan et al.) helps to develop more flexibility as a leader. Being able to switch between both leading and following from moment to moment or day to day demonstrates that you can adapt to different situations and contexts. The chapter helps you to understand how diverse, high-quality career experiences develop your self-complexity which helps you be more adaptable as a leader.
- Chapter 6 (Gatti et al.) focuses on feeling torn between two role-related identities during transitions, in particular between one's role as a leader and as a professional. Reading about identity conflict in this chapter gives you an example for an experience that is similar to what we discussed as liminality in the current chapter.
- Chapter 8 (Lord et al.) helps to further understand how active identities cue leadership knowledge and behavior. The chapter explores how memory relates to leadership, how it is organized and then accessed for use in specific situations.
- Chapter 11 (Guillen et al.) complements this chapter by showing how the social world contributes to your identity of seeing yourself as a leader or a follower. The chapter explains social validation and why it is relevant for your day-to-day identity.

Key Reading

- Ashford, S. J., & DeRue, D. S. (2012). Developing as a leader. *Organizational Dynamics*, *41*(2), 146–154. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.orgdyn.2012.01.008

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Further Reading

- Epitropaki, O., Kark, R., Mainemelis, C., & Lord, R. G. (2017). Leadership and followership identity processes: A multilevel review. *The Leadership Quarterly, 28*(1), 104–129. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.leaqua.2016.10.003
- Nieberle, K. W., Acton, B. P., Braun, S., Lord, R. G., & Fu, Y. (2024). Leader Identity on the Fly: Intra-personal Leader Identity Dynamics in Response to Strong Events. *Journal of Business and Psychology*, *39*, 755–778. https://doi.org/10.1007/s10869-023-09906-7

Other Recommended Sources

- Carmichael, S. G. (Host). (2018, November 20). How your identity changes when you change jobs (No. 657) [Audio podcast episode]. In *HBR IdeaCast*. Harvard Business Review. https://hbr.org/podcast/2018/11/how-your-identity-changes-when-you-change-jobs
- Carmichael, S. G. (Host). (2017, August 31).Why everyone should see themselves as a leader (No. 592) [Audio podcast episode]. In *HBR IdeaCast*. Harvard Business Review. https://hbr.org/podcast/2017/08/why-everyone-should-see-themselves-as-a-leader

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